the Chumbi Valley, a thin strip of Tibetan land between Sikkim and Bhutan, was historically part of Sikkim. 'Its inhabitants had close affinities in language, dress and social custom, with the people comprised within Sikkim's present day boundaries.'[21] It had also, because of its milder climate, been the summer headquarters of the Sikkimese ruler. But after the 1959 invasion of Tibet, Rustomji wrote, the Chinese took care 'to occupy the Chumbi Valley in strength lest the Sikkimese should harbour dreams of revising old claims'. The Chinese also 'accelerated the processes of "de-Tibetanizing" by deputing leading people of the area and brighter lights of the younger generation of China for "cultural integration".'[22]

What had been 'an enchanted frontier' when Rustomji was in Sikkim in the 1950s became, shortly after he had left, a tense and endangered frontier. The first skirmish with the Chinese PLA occurred even before the 1962 War. On 20 September 1960, a PLA patrol intruded into Sikkimese territory near Jelep La and, when the Indian side wanted to discuss the border between Sikkim and Tibet as part of the overall talks about the frontier, the Chinese said that, the issue did 'not fall within the scope' of those discussions.[23]

Tension escalated after the 1962 War as the Chinese amassed even more troops into the Chumbi Valley. In January 1963, the Chinese accused India of having built pill-boxes, communication trenches, and sentry posts to 'the southeast, northeast and north of Nathu La', demanding that India should dismantle all structures set up on 'Chinese territory.' India refuted the claim.[24]

All that had happened was that a new road had been built from Gangtok to Nathu La, a pass north of Jelep La, in 1958, at a time when cross-border trade between Sikkim and Tibet was still being conducted. But the Agreement on Trade and Intercourse between Tibet Region of China and India, which was concluded in 1954, expired on 6 June 1962, and, at a time when tension was mounting along the frontier, there was no interest on either side to have the agreement extended. All kinds of cross-border traffic were halted and the border was sealed. Indian troops had since then been stationed at the pass to guard the frontier, and possibly also to keep an eye on Chinese troop movements in the Chumbi Valley on the other side.

Chinese provocations continued in 1964. In August, a Chinese patrol intruded into Nathu La and on three occasions in December, Chinese